Forward and Backprop

Tuesday, November 10, 2026 11:22 AM

Section 3.3: Forward Pass and Backpropagation

From Prediction to Learning

AI-IM Class — Lecture Notes [Student Copy]

In Section 3.2 we learned that gradient descent improves a model by repeating two things: compute the loss, then nudge every parameter against its gradient. For a neural network this cycle has two halves:

- the **forward pass**, which turns an input $\mathbf{x}$ into a prediction $\hat{y}$ and a loss J, and
- **backpropagation**, which works out how much each weight contributed to that loss, giving the gradient $\partial J/\partial w$.

We will compute the forward pass by hand, see the *idea* behind backpropagation, and then check that one update step really lowers the loss.

1 The Network

We work with a **two-layer feedforward network** (one hidden layer) for the XOR problem:

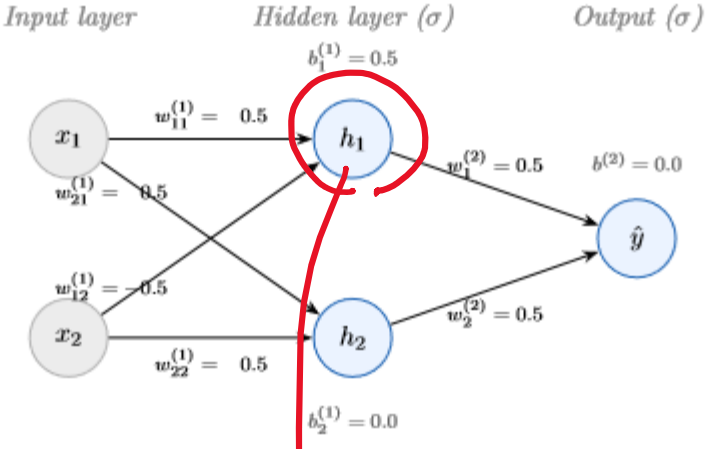


Figure 1: A two-layer feedforward network with one hidden layer.

In matrix form, the (not yet trained) parameters are

$$\mathbf{W}^{(1)} = \begin{bmatrix} 0.5 & -0.5 \\ 0.5 & 0.5 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{b}^{(1)} = \begin{bmatrix} 0.5 \\ 0.0 \end{bmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{W}^{(2)} = \begin{bmatrix} 0.5 & 0.5 \end{bmatrix}, \quad b^{(2)} = 0.0,$$

where row i of $\mathbf{W}^{(1)}$ holds the weights *feeding into* hidden unit i.

where row i of $\mathbf{W}^{(1)}$ holds the weights *feeding into* hidden unit i.

1.1 The Sigmoid Activation

In Section 3.1 we used the **step function**. Its derivative is 0 almost everywhere, so gradient descent would get no signal about which way to move the weights. We therefore

use its smooth "S-shaped" version, the **sigmoid**:

$$\sigma(z) = \frac{1}{1 + e^{-z}}, \qquad \sigma(z) \in (0, 1).$$

Every hidden and output neuron does two sub-steps:

1. **Pre-activation** z: a weighted sum of inputs plus bias.
2. **Activation** $h = \sigma(z)$: squeeze z into $(0, 1)$.

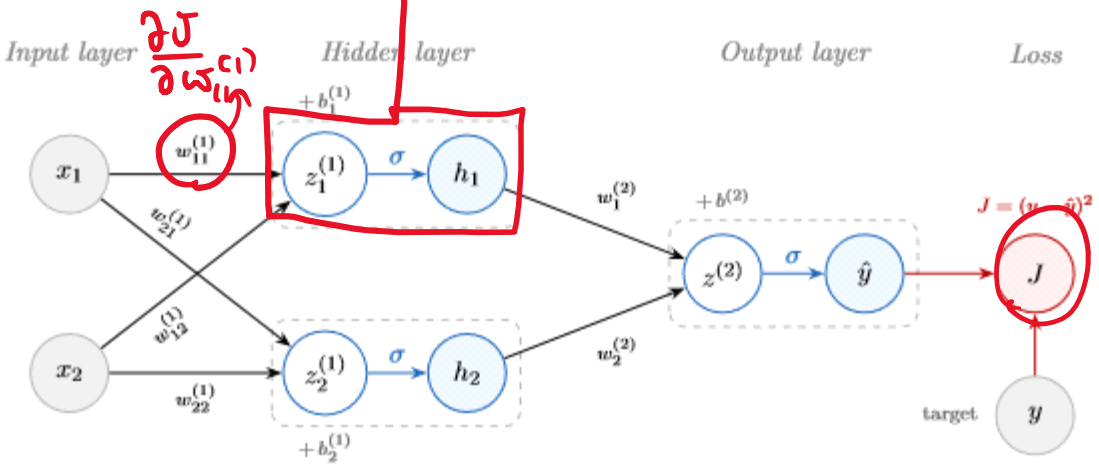


Figure 2: The same network with each neuron (dashed box) split into its pre-activation z (white) and activation (blue). The prediction $\hat{y}$ is compared with the target y to give the loss J.

```python
import numpy as np

def sigmoid(x):
    return 1 / (1 + np.exp(-x))
```

2 The Forward Pass

2 The Forward Pass

We feed the XOR input $\mathbf{x} = (x_1, x_2) = (0, 1)$, whose target is $y = 1$.

Step 1 Hidden layer

Weighted sums entering each hidden neuron:

$$z_1^{(1)} = w_{11}^{(1)} x_1 + w_{12}^{(1)} x_2 + b_1^{(1)} = (0.5)(0) + (-0.5)(1) + 0.5 = \underline{0.0}$$
$$z_2^{(1)} = w_{21}^{(1)} x_1 + w_{22}^{(1)} x_2 + b_2^{(1)} = (0.5)(0) + (0.5)(1) + 0.0 = \underline{0.5}$$

Apply the sigmoid:

$$h_1 = \sigma(z_1^{(1)}) = \underline{0.5}, \qquad h_2 = \sigma(z_2^{(1)}) = \underline{0.622}$$

Step 2 Output layer

$$z^{(2)} = w_1^{(2)} h_1 + w_2^{(2)} h_2 + b^{(2)} = (0.5)(0.500) + (0.5)(0.622) + 0.0 = \underline{0.561}$$
$$\hat{y} = \sigma(z^{(2)}) = \underline{0.637}$$

Step 3 Loss

Using the squared error:

$$J = (y - \hat{y})^2 = (1 - 0.637)^2 \approx \underline{0.132}$$

The network outputs 0.637 when it should output 1. A perfect prediction would give $J = 0$. Our goal now is to change the weights so that J goes down.

3 Backpropagation: The Idea

Gradient descent (Section 3.2) updates every parameter with

$$w \longleftarrow w - \eta \frac{\partial J}{\partial w}.$$

So we need $\partial J / \partial w$ for *every* weight and bias: nine numbers for our small network, and millions for a real one. The difficulty is that the loss depends on a weight only *indirectly*, through a chain of intermediate values.

millions for a real one. The difficulty is that the loss depends on a weight only *indirectly*, through a chain of intermediate values:

$$w_{12}^{(1)} \;\to\; z_1^{(1)} \;\to\; h_1 \;\to\; z^{(2)} \;\to\; \hat{y} \;\to\; J.$$

3.1 The Chain Rule

If y depends on u, and u depends on x, then

$$\frac{dy}{dx} = \frac{dy}{du} \cdot \frac{du}{dx}.$$

Longer chains simply multiply more factors.

Example 3.1. Let $y = (2x+1)^2$. Write $u = 2x+1$ so that $y = u^2$:

$$\frac{dy}{dx} = \underbrace{\frac{dy}{du}}_{2u} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{du}{dx}}_{2} = \underline{\qquad 4(2x+1) \qquad}.$$

3.2 Walking Backwards Through the Network

Each arrow in Figure 2 is a simple function whose derivative is easy (a weighted sum or a sigmoid). The chain rule says:

the gradient of J with respect to a weight is the product of the local derivatives along the path from J back to that weight.

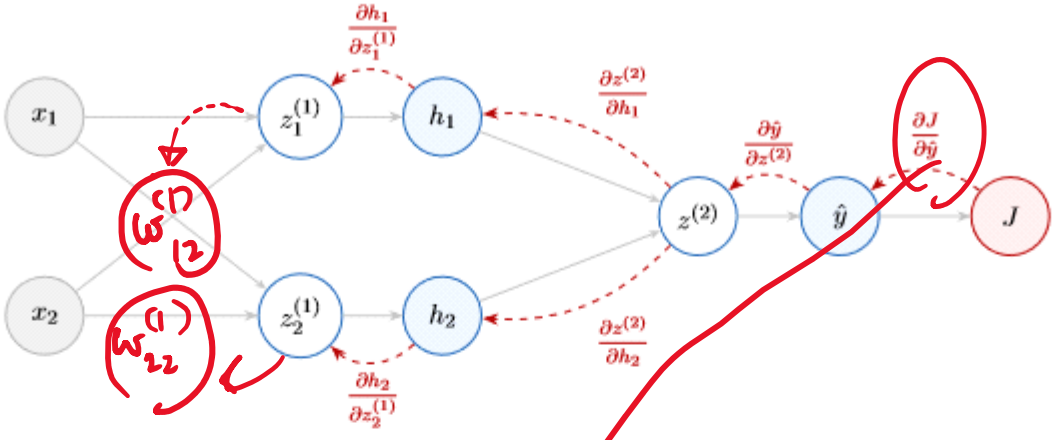


Figure 3: Backpropagation runs the forward graph in reverse. Starting from J, it multiplies the local derivative on each dashed arrow. Paths share their first links ($J \to \hat{y} \to z^{(2)}$), so those products are computed once and reused for every weight further back.

$(J \to \hat{y} \to z^{(2)})$, so those products are computed once and reused for every weight further back.

For example, the gradient for $w_{12}^{(1)}$ is the product along its path:

$$\frac{\partial J}{\partial w_{12}^{(1)}} = \underbrace{\frac{\partial J}{\partial \hat{y}}}_{2(\hat{y}-y)} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{\partial \hat{y}}{\partial z^{(2)}}}_{\sigma'(z^{(2)})} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{\partial z^{(2)}}{\partial h_1}}_{w_1^{(2)}} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{\partial h_1}{\partial z_1^{(1)}}}_{\sigma'(z_1^{(1)})} \cdot \underbrace{\frac{\partial z_1^{(1)}}{\partial w_{12}^{(1)}}}_{x_2}.$$

What to remember about backpropagation.

1. It starts at the loss with the **error** $\dfrac{\partial J}{\partial \hat{y}} = 2(\hat{y} - y)$, i.e. "prediction minus target".
2. Moving back one layer multiplies in that layer's weight and one activation slope $\sigma'(z)$. For the sigmoid, $\sigma'(z) = \sigma(z)\big(1 - \sigma(z)\big) \le 0.25$.
3. At the end, each weight's gradient is

$$\frac{\partial J}{\partial w} = (\text{error signal at its neuron}) \times (\text{input to that weight}).$$

A weight whose input is 0 gets zero gradient: it had no effect on this prediction.

Nobody does this by hand. Deep-learning libraries record the forward pass and apply the chain rule automatically (*automatic differentiation*). In PyTorch, for example, a single call to `loss.backward()` fills in $\partial J/\partial w$ for every parameter.

4 One Update Step

Running backpropagation on our input $(0, 1)$ and applying $w \leftarrow w - \eta\, \partial J/\partial w$ with learning rate $\eta = 0.1$ gives the following new parameters:

0.5 − 0.1 (−0.084)

Parameter	Old	Gradient $\partial J/\partial(\cdot)$	New
$w_1^{(2)}$	0.5	−0.084	0.508
$w_2^{(2)}$	0.5	−0.105	0.510
$b^{(2)}$	0.0	−0.168	0.017
$w_{11}^{(1)}$	0.5	0.000	0.500
$w_{12}^{(1)}$	−0.5	−0.021	−0.498

$w_{11}^{(1)}$	0.5	0.000	0.500
$w_{12}^{(1)}$	-0.5	-0.021	-0.498
$b_1^{(1)}$	0.5	-0.021	0.502
$w_{21}^{(1)}$	0.5	0.000	0.506
$w_{22}^{(1)}$	0.5	-0.020	0.502
$b_2^{(1)}$	0.0	-0.020	0.002

Notice that:

- All non-zero gradients are **negative**, so every parameter that moves goes *up*, which pushes $\hat{y}$ up towards $y = 1$.
- $w_{11}^{(1)}$ and $w_{21}^{(1)}$ have zero gradient because their input is $x_1 = 0$, so they stay put.
- The output-layer gradients are larger than the hidden-layer ones: each step back multiplies in another factor $\sigma'(z) \leq 0.25$.

4.1 Did the Loss Go Down?

Run the forward pass again on the same input $(x_1, x_2) = (0, 1)$, this time with the **new** parameters.

Step 1 Hidden layer

$$z_1^{(1)} = (0.500)(0) + (-0.498)(1) + 0.502 = \underline{0.004}$$
$$z_2^{(1)} = (0.500)(0) + (0.502)(1) + 0.002 = \underline{0.504}$$
$$h_1 = \sigma(z_1^{(1)}) = \underline{0.501}, \qquad h_2 = \sigma(z_2^{(1)}) = \underline{0.623}$$

Step 2 Output layer

$$z^{(2)} = (0.508)(0.501) + (0.510)(0.623) + 0.017 = \underline{0.589}$$
$$\hat{y} = \sigma(z^{(2)}) = \underline{0.643}$$

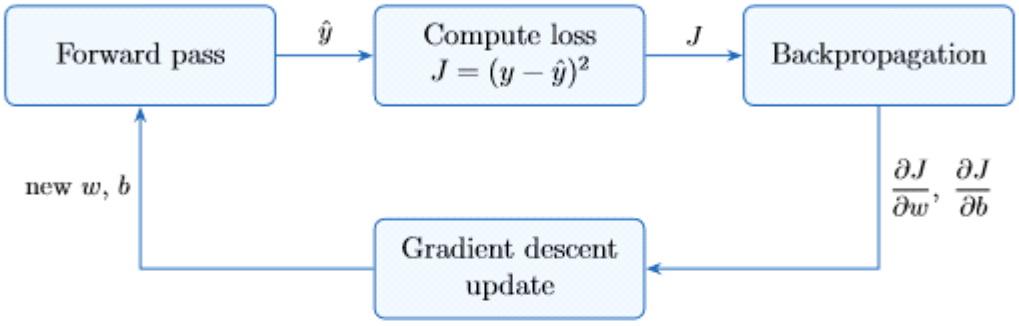
Step 3 Loss

$$J = (1 - 0.643)^2 \approx \underline{0.127}$$

Quantity	Before update	After update
Prediction $\hat{y}$	0.637	0.643
Loss J	0.132	0.127

After one step the prediction has moved closer to the target and the loss has dropped. The change is small, but repeating it many times is what training *is*.

5 The Training Loop



Check out the interactive demo.

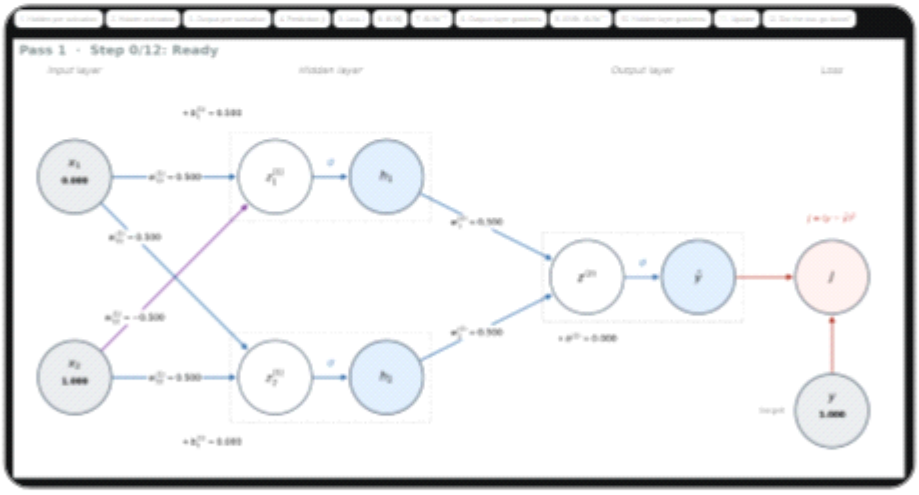


Figure 4: Interactive demo of one forward–backward pass.

6 XOR Problem

In practice we cycle through all four XOR inputs, average the gradients, and take one update step per batch. After hundreds or thousands of such cycles the network correctly classifies all four XOR inputs.

Check out the interactive demo.

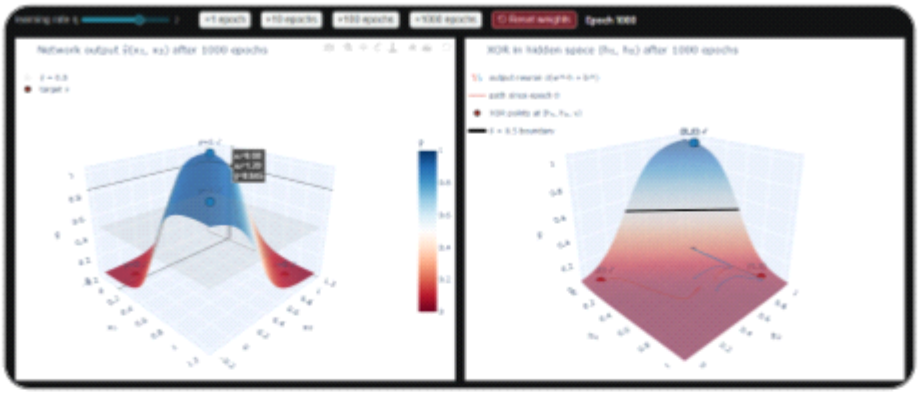


Figure 5: Interactive demo of training on the XOR problem. The network learns to classify the XOR inputs correctly.

7